Lesson 26: Conclusions

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 4.7 Writing a Conclusion; 4.8 Writing Essays (Exercises); and Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 2.6 Writing a Conclusion Paragraph.

In this lesson

You learn how to end an essay: restate your thesis in new words (an umbrella sentence), summarize your main points, and leave the reader with food for thought, while avoiding new material, contradictions and apologies. You analyse two conclusions about stereotypes, then write the conclusion and the title of your own essay and put together your complete first draft. The conclusion is the last paragraph your reader sees, and often the one a lecturer reads just before deciding on a grade.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain how a conclusion mirrors an introduction, moving from specific to general.
- Write an umbrella sentence that restates the thesis in different, simpler words.
- Summarize the main point of each body paragraph without repeating the topic sentences.
- Choose a type of food for thought for the final sentence.
- Avoid new material, contradictions, changes to the thesis, and apologies.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
conclusion (concluding paragraph)	the final paragraph: it wraps up your ideas and leaves readers something to think about	"the last paragraph your readers will read"
restate / paraphrase	say again in different words	Paraphrase your thesis at the beginning of the conclusion.
umbrella sentence	one sentence that gives the main idea of the whole paper; like the thesis, but in different and simpler words	"Stereotypes are harmful because they present flawed and incomplete views of a person or a group of people."
summary	one to three sentences for each body paragraph, reminding readers of your points	"On an individual level, ... On a societal level, ..."

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
food for thought	a final idea that readers will keep thinking about	a suggestion, a prediction, a reflection
call to action	a suggestion that readers do something	challenging readers to change their thoughts or actions
emphatic statement	a strong closing statement	"a final emphatic statement"
the "so what?" conclusion	an ending that shows why the issue matters in the wider world	how your topic fits a global issue
disclaimer	a statement that weakens your responsibility for your own argument	saying that you know your opinion is "tough to digest"
redundant	repeated without need	repeating the exact words of your thesis
undermine	weaken	"a hasty ending can undermine an otherwise strong essay"
closure	the feeling that something is complete	"provides closure for your readers"
evenhandedly	fairly, giving balanced attention to each side	"clearly and evenhandedly explain the phenomenon"

Rules and explanations

Why the conclusion matters

- Do not rush the end. A hasty conclusion, or one with loose ends, can undermine a strong essay and make readers doubt all of it.
- If you have written a good introduction and body, the conclusion is often the most logical part to write.
- The conclusion **mirrors** the introduction. The introduction moves from general (the hook) to specific (the thesis). The conclusion moves the other way: it starts with your specific ideas and moves outward, ending on a bigger idea related to your topic.

The three parts of a conclusion

Part	What it does	Book example
Umbrella sentence	restates the thesis at the start of the conclusion, in **different words**; it can be simpler and less detailed; like an umbrella, it covers all your points	thesis: "The problem with stereotypes is not that they are untrue, but that they are incomplete, and make one story become the only story." umbrella: "Stereotypes are harmful because they present flawed and incomplete views of a person or a group of people."
Summary	reviews the main idea of each body paragraph in one to three sentences, in words different from your topic sentences	"On a societal level, stereotypes can lead to policies that discriminate against particular groups of people."

Part	What it does	Book example
Food for thought	a final idea that leaves the reader thinking about why your ideas matter	see the three examples in Exercise 2

Repeating the exact words of your thesis is redundant; paraphrase it.

Types of food for thought

- a suggestion (or call to action);
- an explanation of why the topic is important or what you want readers to learn;
- a reflection on how your own thinking changed through writing;
- a prediction or warning for the future;
- a return to the hook, explaining how your paper changes our understanding of it (the essay comes "full circle").

Hall and Wallace add three similar techniques: end with a **final emphatic statement**; **challenge readers** to change their thoughts or actions; or show how your topic fits into the larger world (the **"so what?"** conclusion: why does this issue matter?).

Food for thought and "no new material" do not conflict: food for thought widens the view (importance, consequences, the future), but it does not add new evidence or a new point that would need support.

What to avoid

Avoid	Why (Hall and Wallace)
introducing new material	It unsettles readers: they want more information, which you cannot give in one final paragraph.
contradicting or changing your thesis	Readers think you have no conviction, so they are less inclined to believe your original argument.
apologies or disclaimers	You admit that what you discussed is irrelevant or unconvincing. Stand by your thesis.

Advanced academic writers do not usually announce the end with phrases such as *in conclusion*, *it is clear that*, *as you can see* or *in summation*. While you are still developing your essay skills, a closing transition is acceptable.

Balance, title and order of writing

- Keep the introduction and conclusion about the same length, and let them mirror each other.
- Add an engaging title to draw readers in.
- Many writers write the introduction and conclusion last, after the body paragraphs.

Psychology note: a psychology research report ends with a Discussion section, where writers are expected to state the study's limitations and suggest future research. This is not an apology: in psychology, acknowledging limitations makes a paper more credible.

Practice

Exercise 1. Thesis and umbrella sentence. Compare the thesis and the umbrella sentence in the table above.

1. Which idea do they share?
2. In what ways is the umbrella sentence simpler and less detailed?

Exercise 2. Types of food for thought. Which type is each sentence? (Winer and Wadell, "Identifying food for thought")

1. By working hard to combat our own biases and speaking up when we see a "single story" dominate, we can lessen the damaging impact of stereotypes and make the world a safer, more equitable place.
2. Researching the topic of bias revealed some large gaps in my understanding, and now I realize that more than ever, identifying and addressing our own personal biases is critical.
3. Although it may be easier to avoid the potential discomfort of considering more than a "single story" about a person or group of people, failure to take multiple stories into account risks a bleak, increasingly polarized future.

Exercise 3. The conclusion on stereotype threat. Read the conclusion in "Identifying the parts of a conclusion" (it begins "In 'Stereotype Threat,' McRaney and her colleagues ...").

1. Find the umbrella sentence, the summary and the food for thought.
2. The essay's thesis (Lesson 24) was: "Overall, McRaney and her colleagues make an understandable and compelling argument for the existence of stereotype threat; the information they present is engaging, seems balanced, and helped me make sense of my own experiences." Which summary sentence matches each of its three reasons?
3. What type of food for thought is the last sentence?

Exercise 4. Working backwards. Read the conclusion in "Identifying the summary" (it begins "Stereotypes are harmful because ...").

1. The summary sentences in brackets show the contents of the body paragraphs. Write a possible topic sentence for each of the three body paragraphs.
2. What type of food for thought is the last sentence?

Exercise 5. What to avoid. In one sentence each, explain why a conclusion should not:

1. introduce new material;
2. contradict or change the thesis;
3. apologize for the writer's opinion;
4. repeat the exact words of the thesis.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my thesis: [paste]. I will write three umbrella sentences for it. Tell me which one keeps the meaning best in different, simpler words."

- "Here is my conclusion: [paste]. Find the umbrella sentence, the summary and the food for thought. Does it add any new material or weaken my thesis?"
- "Tell me your opinion on a topic in one sentence, like a 'spoken thesis'. I will ask you for three reasons and note them as material for future essays." (the book's journal exercise)
- "I read an article: [title and short summary]. Here is the thesis and the topic sentences I found: [paste]. Did I find them correctly? How does its conclusion end?" (the book's article exercise)
- "Check my answers to Exercises 3 and 4."

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each slash (/).

1. Stereotypes are harmful / because they present flawed and incomplete views / of a person or a group of people.
2. On an individual level, / they take away a person's true identity.
3. On a societal level, / stereotypes can lead to policies / that discriminate against particular groups of people.
4. Failure to take multiple stories into account / risks a bleak, / increasingly polarized future.
5. By working hard to combat our own biases, / we can lessen the damaging impact of stereotypes.

Writing task

Write the conclusion and the title of your essay, then put together your complete first draft: the introduction (Lesson 24), the body paragraphs (Lesson 25) and the conclusion. If you are working on a new topic, write all three parts now; possible topics are stereotypes and the "single story" (the book's topic) or a PSYC 110 topic such as memory or stress and coping.

- Conclusion: about the same length as your introduction (usually 100 to 200 words).
- Parts: an umbrella sentence, a summary of each body paragraph (one to three sentences each, in new words), and one type of food for thought.
- Title: short, clear and engaging.

Self-editing checklist:

- Does my umbrella sentence restate my thesis in different, simpler words?
- Does my summary cover every body paragraph? (Check against my topic sentences.)
- Have I avoided copying my thesis and topic sentences word for word?
- Does my last sentence give clear food for thought? Which type is it?
- Have I avoided new evidence, new points, contradictions and apologies?
- Are my introduction and conclusion about the same length, and do they mirror each other?
- Does my title tell the reader what the essay is about?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. Stereotypes are incomplete: they give an incomplete view of people.
2. It drops the contrast "not that they are untrue, but ..." and the image "make one story become the only story"; it states the main point directly with new words ("harmful", "flawed and incomplete views of a person or a group of people"). It covers the same general information but is less detailed. (book: "less detailed")

Exercise 2 (book)

1. A suggestion or call to action.
2. A reflection on how your own thinking changed through writing.
3. A prediction or warning for the future.

Exercise 3

1. (book) Umbrella sentence: "In 'Stereotype Threat,' McRaney and her colleagues clearly and evenhandedly explain the phenomenon of stereotype threat." Summary: the next three sentences, from "Their choice of language ..." to "... where stereotype threat may have been at play." Food for thought: "Their chapter highlights an important phenomenon and, with this knowledge, institutions and individuals can take steps to create environments in and out of the classroom that lessen the chance stereotype threat will negatively (and needlessly) affect performance."
2. Engaging: "Their choice of language makes the chapter interesting and accessible ..." Seems balanced: "The authors also spend time addressing and responding to some common criticisms ..." Helped me make sense of my own experiences: "Furthermore, the content is relatable: the examples provided in the text helped me identify an instance of stereotype threat in my own life ..."
3. A suggestion (what institutions and individuals can do), together with an explanation of why the topic is important ("an important phenomenon").

Exercise 4

1. (example answers) (a) Stereotypes harm individuals because they replace a person's true identity with a group label. (b) Stereotypes also harm society when they shape policies that discriminate against particular groups. (c) The most dangerous effect of stereotypes is physical violence against members of a group.
2. A suggestion or call to action (book: it is item 1 in Exercise 2).

Exercise 5

1. New points unsettle readers and make them want information that one final paragraph cannot give.
2. Readers think you do not really believe your argument, so they trust it less.
3. An apology admits that your discussion is irrelevant or unconvincing.
4. It is redundant; restate the thesis in different words.

My notes